



The Girl Cut in Two La Fille coupée en deux

A film by: Claude Chabrol

©: Aliceléo Cinéma, Rhône-Alpes Cinéma,
France 2 Cinéma, Integral Film GmbH

Production Company/Presented by:
Aliceléo Cinéma

Production Companies: Aliceléo, France 2 Cinéma,
Rhône-Alpes Cinéma, Integral Film GmbH
With the participation of: Région Rhône-Alpes,
CNC - Centre national de cinématographie,
Canal+, CinéCinéma

International Sales: Wild Bunch

Executive Producer: Françoise Galfré

Executive Producer (Portugal Crew):

François d'Artémare

Produced by: Patrick Godeau

Co-produced by: Alfred Hürmer

Production Co-ordinator (Portugal Crew):

Alejandra Alem

Production Manager: Michel Jullien

Production Manager (Lyons): Nicolas Porte

Production Manager (Portugal Crew):

Margarida Nunes

Unit Production Manager: Thierry Magniez

Unit Production Manager (Portugal Crew):

Joana Synek

Unit Manager: Alain Barbaut

Location Scout (Lyons): Nicolas Porte

Production Crew (Aliceléo): Francine Lesage,

Anita Salemi, Florence Fusco, Kimel Loucif

1st Assistant Director: Cécile Maistre

Assistant Directors: Vincent Guillerminet,

Mélanie Ravot

2nd Assistant Director (Portugal Crew): Isabel Lebre

Script Supervisor: Aurore Chabrol

Casting: Mademoiselle Chouchou

Casting (Lyons): Maguy Aimé

Scenario: Cécile Maistre, Claude Chabrol

Adaptation/Dialogue: Cécile Maistre,

Claude Chabrol

Director of Photography: Eduardo Serra

Camera Operator: Michel Thiriet

Camera Operator (Portugal Crew):

Miguel Sales Lopes

1st Assistant Camera: Florent Bazin

2nd Assistant Camera: Delphine Desbruères

2nd Assistant Camera (Portugal Crew):

André Godinho

Key Grip: Dominique Robert

Steadicam Operator: Mathieu Caudroy

Gaffer: Michel Atanassian

Portugal Crew Gaffer: Pedro Paiva

Stills Photographer: Moune Jamet

Stills Photographer (Portugal Crew): Rui Mateus

Editor: Monique Fardoulis

Assistant Editors: Stanislas Moreau,

Olivier Rossignol

Art Director: Françoise Benoît-Fresco

Assistant Art Director: Anne Bourleyre

Set Decorator: Catherine Pierrat

Properties: Pierre Galliard

Costumes: Mic Cherminal

Wardrobe: Sandrine Bernard

Dresser: Laurence Glentzlin

Key Make-up: Maya Benamer

Make-up Artists: Aurélie Rameau,

Catherine Pervilhac, Véronique Dejean

Key Hairstylist: Antoine Amador

Hairstylists: Alexandre Laforest, Michel Varela

Hairstylist (Portugal Crew): Anna Ferreira

Titles/Opticals: Artefix

Cameras by: Panavision (France)

Film Stock: Kodak

Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

The Girl Cut in Two

*The screening on Tuesday 6 October will include a Q&A with
Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol*

Claude Chabrol on 'The Girl Cut in Two'

'A chaste film about perversion' is Claude Chabrol's description of his slyly amusing melodrama *The Girl Cut in Two*. His 56th feature tells the story of Gabrielle (Ludivine Sagnier), a television weathergirl who's romantically torn between two contrasting men: novelist Charles (François Berléand), who's several decades older than her, and volatile aristocratic playboy Paul (Benoît Magimel).

The film is inspired by a real-life crime of passion from 1906: the murder of US architect Stanford White, previously dramatised in Richard Fleischer's 1955 film *The Girl in the Red Velvet Swing*, starring Joan Collins. *The Girl Cut in Two* sees the source material transposed from US high society of the 1900s to contemporary Lyon, where nouveaux riches in publishing and television find themselves jostling for power with 'old money' puritans, embodied by Paul's ruthless mother (Caroline Sihol), who scorns the lower-middle-class Gabrielle.

As ever with Chabrol, there's a cunning playfulness at work. Hitchcockian doublings and dualities abound, narrative ellipses confuse our sense of time, and fairytale allusions – Gabrielle as Snow White looking for her Prince Charming – are plentiful. Illusory images prevail – right down to the closing act of magic.

What was the starting point for The Girl Cut in Two? Though it's based on a true story, it has the feel of a dark fairytale.

I wanted to make a film about a young woman who appears on television, who is caught up in a semi-public existence, and who ends up leaving television by fabricating her disappearance. Then I remembered Richard Fleischer's 1955 film *The Girl in the Red Velvet Swing*. I did some research [into the original case] and showed it to Cécile Maistre, who wrote the screenplay. I was struck by how this story could work in any country in any period. Transposing the story to France wasn't a problem – a bourgeois family in France today is very similar to a family of that class in early 20th-century America; their way of thinking is very similar.

Once again you're drawn to the subject of power.

It's not so much the negative impact power has on other people I'm interested in as the impact power has on oneself. I'm interested in the game of power, and the fact that people who think they have it don't realise how ridiculous it is. A filmmaker thinks he or she has power, until the producer says that is the end, then the producer is thrown out by the company that employs him, and so forth. It's an endless process. Power is limited to a certain field and to a certain period of time.

How did you choose the cast?

The real problem was choosing the young woman. I chose an actress who I liked and thought had talent, and who physically corresponded to my idea of the young woman. When I'm looking for an actor, I ask them to come and eat

Laboratory: GTC
 Colour Grading: Christophe Bousquet
 Music: Matthieu Chabrol
 Jingle Music: Niobé
 Orchestra Conducted by: Laurent Petitgirard
 Executive Music Production: OSF Productions
 (Music Recordist: Emmanuel Payet)
 Music Recorded at: Acousti
 Sound Recordist: Éric Devulder
 Sound Mixer: Thierry Lebon
 Assistant Sound Mixer: Vincent Cosson
 ADR Supervisor: Michel Filippi
 ADR Recordist: Jean-Pierre Hoüel
 Foley Artist: Julien Naudin
 English Subtitles by: Cynthia Schoch, Lenny Borger
 Subtitling Paris: Titra Film
 Thanks: Filmes do Tejo
 'Making of': Pierre-Henri Gibert
 Publicity: Casablanca
 Casablanca Publicity: Catherine Emond
 Unit Publicist: Eva Simonet
 Cast:
 Ludivine Sagnier (*Gabrielle Deneige*)
 Benoît Magimel (*Paul Gaudens*)
 François Berléand (*Charles Saint-Denis*)
 Mathilda May (*Capucine Jamet*)
 Caroline Silhol (*Geneviève Gaudens*)
 Marie Bunel (*Marie Deneige*)
 Valéria Cavalli (*Dona Saint-Denis*)
 Étienne Chicot (*Denis Deneige*)
 Édouard Baer (*Édouard, actor*)
 Jean-Marie Winling (*Gérard Briançon*)
 Didier Bénureau (*Philippe Le Riou*)
 Thomas Chabrol (*Maître Lorbach*)
 Charley Fouquet (*Eléonore Gaudens*)
 Hubert Saint Macary (*Bernard Violet*)
 Jérémie Chaplain; Clémence Bretecher; André
 Asseo; Béatrice Audry; Alain Bauguil (*Louis
 Giraudet*); Denis Benoliel; Antoine Bérard; Nicole
 Biondi; Alain Blasquez; Emmanuel Booz (*Alban*);
 Jeanne Brouaye; Benoît Charpentier (*himself*); Mic
 Cheminal; Mathieu Clechet; Stéphane Debac;
 Pierre-François Duméniaud (*Monsieur Junot*);
 Françoise Gambey; Fanny Gatibelza; Pierre-Henri
 Gibert; Vincent Guillerminet; Véronique Kapoian;
 Yannick Laurent; Cécile Maistre (*Cécile*); Gérard
 Moulévrier (*bidder*); Raphaël Neal; Henri-Edouard
 Osinski; Marie Oury, Laurent Paillot, Thomas
 Poulard, Sandra Rebocho; Valentin Traversi,
 Mélanie Vaudaine, Daniel Zieba, Patrick
 Zimmermann
 France-Germany 2006©
 115 mins
 Digital

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 Tamasa Distribution

The BFI will be releasing a selection of
 Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

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with me. I look at how they eat and drink. Ludivine [Sagnier] ate well and
 drank well.

I know Benoît [Magimel] well. He has great potential – he's not stuck in a
 particular type of leading-man part. A lot of actors limit themselves to young,
 good-looking roles, occasionally acting as a serial killer to break their image.
 That's not the case with Benoît. The scriptwriter Cécile Maistre suggested
 François Berléand for the role of Charles. I wasn't sure to what extent he'd be
 credible as a seducer of Ludivine. Then I thought of my friend Romain Gary, a
 French writer with a strange face, but a great womaniser. If he could seduce
 women, then so could Berléand!

*The theme of two men in competition recurs in your work from Le Beau
 Serge on.*

The idea of showing two different facets of men came very early in my
 filmmaking. I chose to portray two men because I understood men better than
 women then. With *Les Biches* (1968) I swapped – instead of having two men,
 as in *Les Cousins* (1959), I had two women. Not cousins but lesbians – but it
 came to the same thing. Women to me are more interesting than men.

What interested you in the visual symbolism of the titular magic trick?

I had the title before I came up with the closing scene, so I needed to justify it. I
 liked the symbolism of a woman being cut in half but staying intact – that to me
 is an advantage women have over men. A man cut in two, like Paul, becomes
 schizophrenic; a woman cut in two suffers, but then comes together again.

*An interesting aspect of The Girl Cut in Two is that the aristocrats are the
 puritans and the nouveaux riches the libertines.*

I know some aristocrats who are leftwing and some leftists who are puritans,
 but in my experience what you say is true. On the whole it is a chaste film
 about perversion – it had to be chaste otherwise it would have been a dirty film.
 Perversion is in one's mind – that's how you deal with it as a filmmaker, without
 showing it. I explained to Ludivine that she wouldn't have to do anything
 uncomfortable: 'There is only one thing – you'll have to go on all fours with a
 feather stuck in your bum.' And she said, 'Oh, that's all right then.' I admired
 her when she said that.

Interview and introduction by Thomas Dawson, *Sight and Sound*, June 2009